Process Creation Investigation – tasklist.exe

Objective

The objective of this investigation is to verify that tasklist.exe process execution events are successfully collected by Elastic SIEM using Sysmon logs. This investigation demonstrates how Windows process enumeration activity can be monitored and analyzed to identify legitimate administrative usage as well as potential attacker reconnaissance.

Command Executed

```
tasklist
```

Detection Method (KQL)

```
process.name : "tasklist.exe"
```

If your environment indexes the event differently, use the query that successfully located it, such as `process.args : "tasklist"`.

Evidence Collected

Timestamp: 2026-07-15T05:41:30.387Z
Process Name: tasklist.exe
Host Name: sepisecurity
User Domain: Sepisecurity
Process ID (PID): 28372
Event Code: 5 (Verify this matches the actual event source.)

Analysis

The investigation confirmed that tasklist.exe executed successfully on the monitored Windows endpoint. The event identified the executing user, host system, process identifier, and execution time. No suspicious parent process, unusual command-line arguments, or indicators of malicious behavior were observed. The activity is consistent with legitimate administrative use of the Windows tasklist utility to enumerate running processes.

Security Impact

The tasklist command is commonly used by administrators to view running processes. Threat actors also use it during reconnaissance to identify security software, running services, and valuable processes before attempting privilege escalation, credential theft, or defense evasion. Monitoring tasklist.exe execution helps SOC analysts identify potentially suspicious process discovery activity when correlated with other endpoint events.

Conclusion

This investigation demonstrates the ability to detect and analyze Windows process creation events using Elastic SIEM and Sysmon. The collected evidence indicates legitimate administrative activity, and no indicators of compromise were identified. This investigation highlights practical skills in KQL searching, endpoint telemetry analysis, and professional SOC documentation.